The Girl at the Doorway

By Vallikkannan

Valliammai (Valli) was an eight-year-old girl with no playmates on her street. Standing at the front door was favorite pastime. Her curiosity fueled an overwhelming desire: she wanted to ride the bus, even if just once.

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A Source of Unending Joy

For Valli, watching the street was as elaborate as any game. The bus passed her street every hour. Seeing it filled with a new set of passengers each time was her greatest thrill.

She would stare wistfully (longingly) at the faces of people getting off, kindling her dreams and hopes.

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The Meticulous Plan

Valli didn't just dream; she planned. Over many months, she listened to neighbors and asked discreet questions to gather exact details.

Valli's Village

The Nearest Town

Distance:
6 miles from the village.

Time:
45 minutes one-way. (Leave at 1:00 PM, return by 2:45 PM).

Cost:
30 paise one-way (a fortune to her!).

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The Price of Independence

Valli thriftily saved every stray coin that came her way. She exhibited immense self-control for a child.

She resolutely stifled (suppressed with determination) a strong desire to ride the merry-go-round at the village fair.

The Result: A total savings of exactly sixty paise.

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"Stop the bus!"

Sneaking out during her mother's afternoon nap (1 PM to 4 PM), Valli commands the bus to stop.

Valli's Response:

"I can get on by myself. You don't have to help me."

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Devouring the World

The bus was a gleaming white with green stripes and silver overhead bars.

Because a canvas blind cut off her view, Valli stood on the seat. She devoured everything with her eyes, taking in the ditch on one side and acres of endless green fields on the other.

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Character Card

Haughty & Proud

“There’s nobody here who’s a child… I’ve paid my thirty paise like everyone else.”

Independent

“I can take care of myself.”

Irritable when patronized

She intensely dislikes the conductor jokingly calling her my fine madam and gets angry when an elderly man tells her to sit down.

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Navigating the Passengers

- **The Conductor:** Amused by her confidence, he playfully calls her madam and punches her ticket.
- **The Elderly Woman:** Valli finds her absolutely repulsive (smelling of betel nut, big ugly earrings). When the woman asks if she is alone with endless drivel (nonsense), Valli answers her curtly.

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The Galloping Cow & The Town

- The highlight of the trip was a frightened cow that ran faster the more the driver honked. Valli laughed until her eyes watered.
- The bus eventually reaches the town's wide thoroughfare, filled with glittering displays of merchandise and big crowds. Valli is struck dumb with wonder.

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Refusing to Explore

Despite reaching her destination, Valli refuses to get off. Her goal was just the bus ride. When the conductor offers to buy her a cold drink, she firmly refuses. She knows she lacks the money and admits she would be much too afraid to wander the town alone.

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The Reality of Death

On the return trip, Valli sees the young cow lying dead by the roadside, struck by a vehicle. What had been a lovable creature just a while ago had lost its charm and life. The memory haunted her, dampening her enthusiasm. She sat glued to her seat, refusing to look out the window again.

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A Secret Well Kept

Valli returns safely at 3:40 PM. She overhears her mother remarking that we can't possibly know about everything in the outside world. Valli whispers, "Oh, yes!" Her aunt dismisses her as a chit of a girl who pokes her nose into grown-up conversations. Valli just smiles to herself, keeping her journey a secret.

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SUPER REVISION: Plot Timeline

1. The Desire: Yearns to ride the bus; gathers info discreetly.

2. The Sacrifice: Resists temptations to save exactly 60 paise.

3. The Departure: Sneaks out at 1:00 PM; asserts independence on the bus.

4. The Joy: Devours the sights; laughs at the running cow.

5. The Boundary: Reaches town but refuses to get off or accept a free drink.

6. The Tragedy: Sees the dead cow on the return; realizes the reality of death.

7. The Return: Arrives home with a secret adult experience.

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BOARD VOCABULARY MATRIX

VOCABULARY WORD	DEFINITION
Wistfully	Longingly / with deep desire.
Discreet	Careful, cautious, and quiet in gathering information.
Slack time	A period with not much work or few passengers.
Devoured	Looked at eagerly, taking in every detail.
Haughtily	Proudly, showing a sense of superiority.
Resolutely stifled	Suppressed or controlled a strong desire with determination.
Drivel	Silly, meaningless nonsense.
Spreadeagled	Lying with arms and legs spread out awkwardly.

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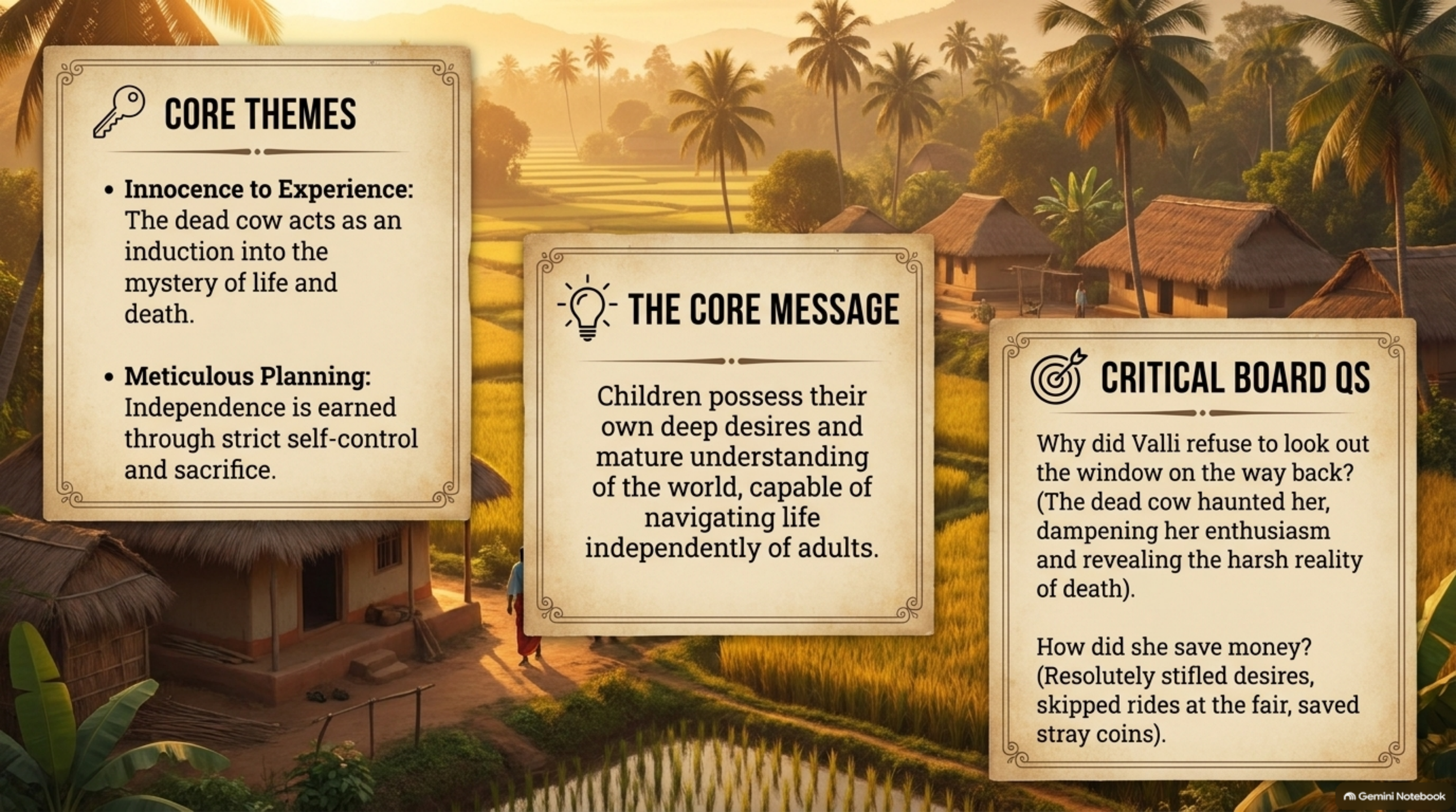

CORE THEMES

- **Innocence to Experience:** The dead cow acts as an induction into the mystery of life and death.
- **Meticulous Planning:** Independence is earned through strict self-control and sacrifice.

THE CORE MESSAGE

Children possess their own deep desires and mature understanding of the world, capable of navigating life independently of adults.

CRITICAL BOARD QS

Why did Valli refuse to look out the window on the way back? (The dead cow haunted her, dampening her enthusiasm and revealing the harsh reality of death).

How did she save money? (Resolutely stifled desires, skipped rides at the fair, saved stray coins).

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